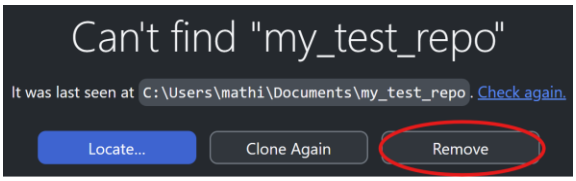
Block 3: clone and fetch

Part I: Clone a repository

Step 1. Delete your local folder

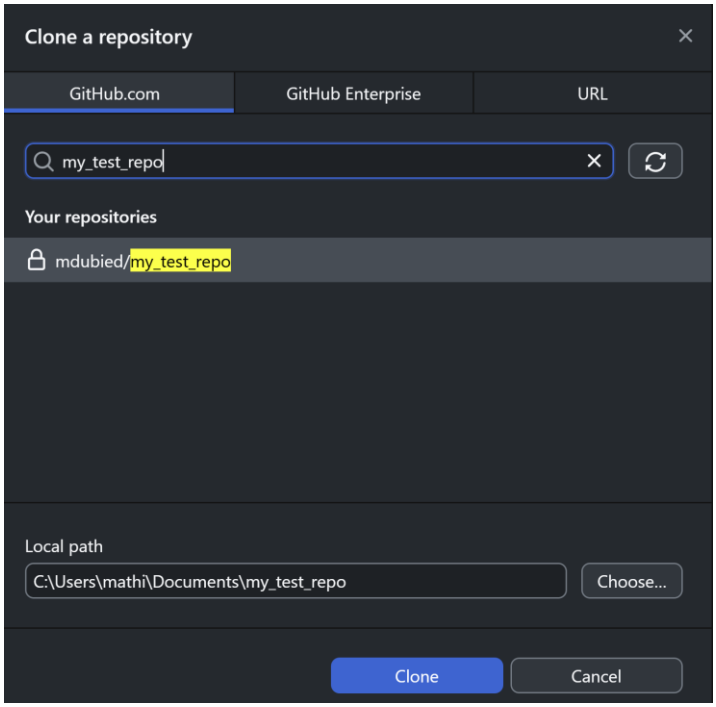
- In GitHub Desktop, check that there is nothing left to commit or push ("No local changes")
- Close the files of `my_test_repo` you may have open, then delete the `my_test_repo` folder on your computer
- Go back to GitHub Desktop. It shows "Can't find my_test_repo": click "Remove"



Your work is not lost: it is simply not on your computer anymore, but still on GitHub web.

Step 2. Clone your remote repository

- In GitHub Desktop, go to File --> Clone repository...
- In the "GitHub.com" tab, select `my_test_repo`
- Choose a local path and click "Clone"



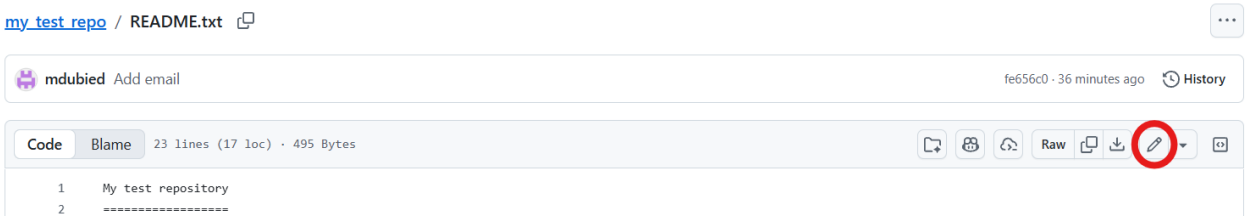
"Cloning" here means making a copy of the repository that lives online (on GitHub web) on your computer. If you right-click on "Current repository" and select "Show in Explorer" (or "Show on Finder" on Mac), you will find your files.

You can do the same to get your project on a second computer, or to download a colleague's repository.

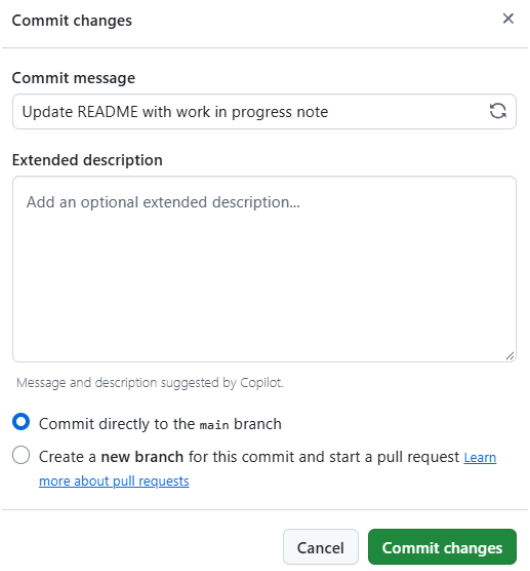
Part II: Fetch from remote

Step 3. Edit a file on GitHub web

- Open your repository on GitHub web (https://github.com/{your_username}/my_test_repo) and click on `README.txt`
- Click on the pencil icon ("Edit this file"), and add a line under "Notes" at the end of the document, for example "This is work in progress. Contact the author for any questions."



- Click "Commit changes...", write a message, and click "Commit changes"

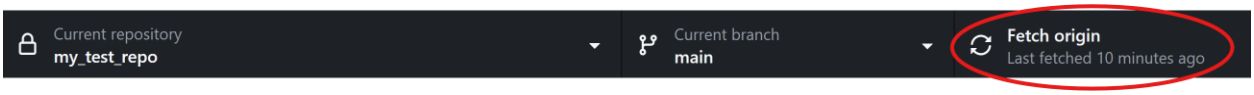


Did this change also affect the file on your computer? Have a look.

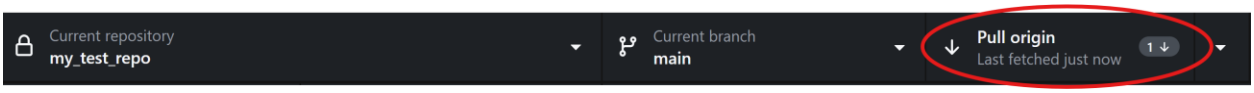
Answer: it did not. What you just did was to change the online version, while the version on your computer (we call it the "local" version) is not automatically affected. In this case, we say that the online version (also sometimes called "the remote") is "one commit ahead" compared to the version of your computer.

Step 4. Fetch and pull the updates

- In GitHub Desktop, click “Fetch origin” (top bar)



- The button becomes “Pull origin”: click on it



- Open `README.txt` on your computer: it contains the change you made on GitHub

What you just did was to obtain the version of the online repository to your computer. In GitHub terms, we first "fetch", meaning we check wether there are new changes (new "commits") on GitHub. We then "pull", meaning we download the web version into the folder of our computer.

Your notes: